

Physics-Infused Reduced-Order Modeling for Analysis of Multi-Layered Hypersonic Thermal Protection Systems With Unknown Thermal Contact Resistances

Abstract

This work presents a systematic application of the physics-infused reduced-order modeling (PIROM) framework to the analysis of multi-layered hypersonic thermal protection systems (TPS) with unknown thermal contact resistances (TCRs).

1 Introduction

Importance of hypersonic TPS Hypersonic thermal protection systems (TPS) play a critical role in safeguarding hypersonic vehicles as they are exposed to extreme aerodynamic heating during flight. Therefore, accurate modeling and prediction of TPS behavior become essential for designing effective thermal protection strategies. Nonetheless, the highly non-linear fluid-thermal-structural interactions, temperature-dependent material property variations, and uncertainties in thermal contact resistances (TCR) at the interfaces of the TPS layers, pose significant challenges for traditional modeling approaches such as finite-element methods (FEM), as well as reduced-order (ROM) and surrogate (SM) modeling techniques.

What is the new problem that we want to solve? Particularly, a critical artifact in transient reduced-order modeling of hypersonic TPS is the presence of TCRs. Due to manufacturing limitations, when two solids are brought together to form an interface, the true solid-to-solid contact area between them is generally a small fraction of the apparent area over which they meet [Minges1970]. The net effect of imperfect contact is the formation of a temperature discontinuity at the interface that is in general challenging to predict, and that significantly affects the heat transfer across the interface. The identification of TPS properties from internal temperature measurements belongs to a class of *inverse heat conduction problem* (IHCP) [Deng2026], which are known to be ill-posed and sensitive to measurement noise, and thus require careful regularization and robust inference techniques for accurate estimation of TCRs. The challenges posed by IHCPs can introduce significant uncertainties in transient temperature predictions, and thus compromise the reliability of ROMs for design, analysis, and optimization of hypersonic TPS [Fang2023]. Therefore, there is a critical need for *efficient, accurate, and generalizable* modeling approaches of TPS that can infer TCRs, while providing reliable predictions of internal TPS transient temperatures under varying boundary conditions and material properties.

What has been done in the literature for inference and simulation? Attempts to modeling hypersonic TPS with varying TCRs have taken various forms in the literature, ranging from traditional deterministic physics-based modeling approaches, to probabilistic approaches, and more

recently, to scientific machine learning (SciML) techniques that leverage the strengths of both physics-based and data-driven modeling paradigms. For instance, in Ref. [Fang2023], a Lattice Boltzmann Method (LBM) is used to model the transient heat transfer and solid-liquid phase change in a hypersonic TPS, where the TCRs are assumed known, and are shown to significantly delay the melting points of phase changing materials. In Ref. [Zhang2024], authors take one step further by treating the TCRs as unknown parameters, and a finite-element thermo-mechanical model of a three-dimensional reusable heat-pipe cooled thermal protection system is developed to perform Levenberg-Marquardt gradient-based inference of internal TCRs using boundary temperature measurements. A similar approach is adopted in Ref. [Brociek2024], where a finite-difference one-dimensional model of a three-layered TPS is developed to solve the forward problem, and a Levenberg-Marquardt for a Tikhonov regularized optimization is used to solve the inverse problem of inferring TCRs from internal temperature measurements.

Probabilistic approaches to solving the inverse problem of inferring TCRs have also been proposed in the literature. For instance, in Ref. [Gao2026], a Bayesian Network (BN) with sequential importance resample (SIR) is leveraged for probabilistic inversion of TCRs, where the BN is implemented by leveraging a finite-element model of the multi-layered TPS for forward simulations. A BN is also leveraged in Ref. [Deng2026] to infer TCRs, where a neural network is used as a surrogate model to predict internal temperature dynamics due to the computational cost of the FEM-based forward model.

The use of scientific machine learning (SciML) techniques for modeling hypersonic TPS with unknown TCRs has limited exploration in the literature.

.... Other X approaches such as those in Refs.[X] ...

While these methods offer a high-fidelity representation of the underlying physics, highly refined FEMs result in large-scale systems that are computationally expensive to solve, and thus are not suitable for design, analysis, and optimization of hypersonic TPS.

Other data-driven approaches such as those in Refs.[X] ..., leverage Bayesian Networks (BNs) to learn mappings from boundary conditions and thermocop

machine learning techniques to learn the underlying dynamics of the TPS system directly from data, while inferring the TCRs. For instance, in Refs. [X]...

While these methods offer computational efficiency, they often require large amounts of data for training, and may not generalize well to unseen conditions, such as varying boundary conditions and material properties. Moreover, they may not provide insights into the underlying physics of the system, which can be critical for design and optimization.

Objectives of the work The objectives of this work include:

1. Demonstrate the systematic application of PIROM for modeling hypersonic TPS with unknown contact resistances, emphasizing on the simultaneous inference of contact conductances and hidden dynamics under varying boundary conditions and material properties.
2. Benchmark the performance of PIROM against traditional physics-based modeling approaches (e.g., one-dimensional FEM) and data-driven surrogate models (e.g., neural ordinary differential equations) for both inferring contact conductances and transient TPS temperature dynamics.
3. Provide insights into the optimal design of physics-based models for inference of contact conductances, including the resolution of the physics-based model, noise levels, and placement constraints o

2 Modeling of Hypersonic Protection Systems

The following discussion introduces the governing equations in the heat conduction problem for hypersonic TPS with unknown contact resistances. Moreover, three different physics-based approaches of decreasing fidelity are presented for solving the governing equations: (i) a fine three-dimensional FEM termed the *full-order model* (FOM), (ii) a one-dimensional FEM with linear elements termed the *one-dimensional FEM* (1D-FEM), and (iii) a lumped-mass representation of the TPS termed the *lumped capacitance model* (LCM). The governing equations and their three solutions strategies are presented next.

2.1 Governing Equations

Consider the generic domain $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^d$ with $d = 1, 2, 3$ as show in Fig. X. A heat flux q_b (i.e., Neumann boundary condition) is prescribed on boundary Γ_q , while a temperature T_b (i.e., Dirichlet boundary condition) is prescribed on boundary Γ_T , and $\partial\Omega = \Gamma_q \cup \Gamma_T$. The transient heat conduction dynamics is governed by the following energy equation

2.2 Full-Order Model

The FOM is described by a three-dimensional finite-element model of the four-layered TPS shown in Fig. [X], where the TCRs are treated as unknown parameters.

2.3 One-Dimensional Model

This approach follows the classical FEM approach with a linear basis function to capture the through-thickness spatially-varying temperature distributions inside each component of the TPS. This modeling simplification is commonly used in the literature for modeling heat conduction in multi-layered TPS, since under hypersonic thermal loading, the temperature gradient along the thickness direction of the structure is significantly higher than the in-plane temperature gradients, and thus the through-thickness temperature distribution dominates the overall thermal response of the system [Gao2026].

As with the FOM, the TCR introduces additional considerations in the formulation of the 1D-FEM.

3 Lumped Capacitance Model

This work leverages the *lumped capacitance model* (LCM) as the physics-based component in the PIROM. The LCM is a classical physics-based low-order model for predicting the temporal variation of average temperature in multiple connected components [Incropera2011]. The LCM is usually derived at the component level from an energy balance standpoint, where the followin assumptions are employed: (i) component i has uniform temperature $\bar{u}_i(t)$; (ii) between neighboring components i and j the heat flux is given by,

$$q_{ij} = \frac{\bar{u}_j - \bar{u}_i}{R_{ij}} \quad (1)$$

Specifically, the LCM is treated as a coarse-grained representation of a DG-FEM model of the TPS, as demonstrated in previous work [VargasVenegas2026]. In this model, each layer of the TPS is treated as a lumped mass with an average temperature, and the heat transfer between adjacent

layers is modeled as a function of the temperature difference between them. Nonetheless, the presence of TCRs at the interfaces introduces additional modeling considerations, as the temperature drop across the interface is not solely due to the bulk thermal resistance of the adjacent layers, but also includes a contribution from the contact resistance.

Consider the lumped-mass average temperature state,

$$\mathbf{u} = [u_1, u_2, u_3, u_4]^T \in \mathbb{R}^N \quad (2)$$

and temperature-dependent lumped-capacitance matrix,

$$A(\mathbf{u}) = \begin{bmatrix} a_1(u_1) & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & a_2(u_2) & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & a_3(u_3) & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & a_4(u_4) \end{bmatrix} \quad (3)$$

Let the external Neumann forcing be applied to the first lumped mass,

$$\mathbf{f}(t) = \begin{bmatrix} f(t) \\ 0 \\ 0 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix} \quad (4)$$

For interfaces $i = 1, 2, 3$, define the known *bulk resistances*

$$S_i(\mathbf{u}) = R_i^-(\mathbf{u}) + R_i^+(\mathbf{u}) \quad (5)$$

and the unknown contact resistance,

$$R_{xi} > 0, \quad g_{xi} := \frac{1}{R_{xi}}. \quad (6)$$

The classical lumped-capacitance model with effective series resistances is,

$$A(\mathbf{u}) \dot{\mathbf{u}} = B(\mathbf{u}) \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{f}(t) \quad (7)$$

where,

$$B(\mathbf{u}) = \sum_{i=1}^{N-1} \frac{1}{S_i(\mathbf{u}) + R_{xi}} \mathbf{K}_i \quad (8)$$

with standard nearest-neighbor diffusion stencils,

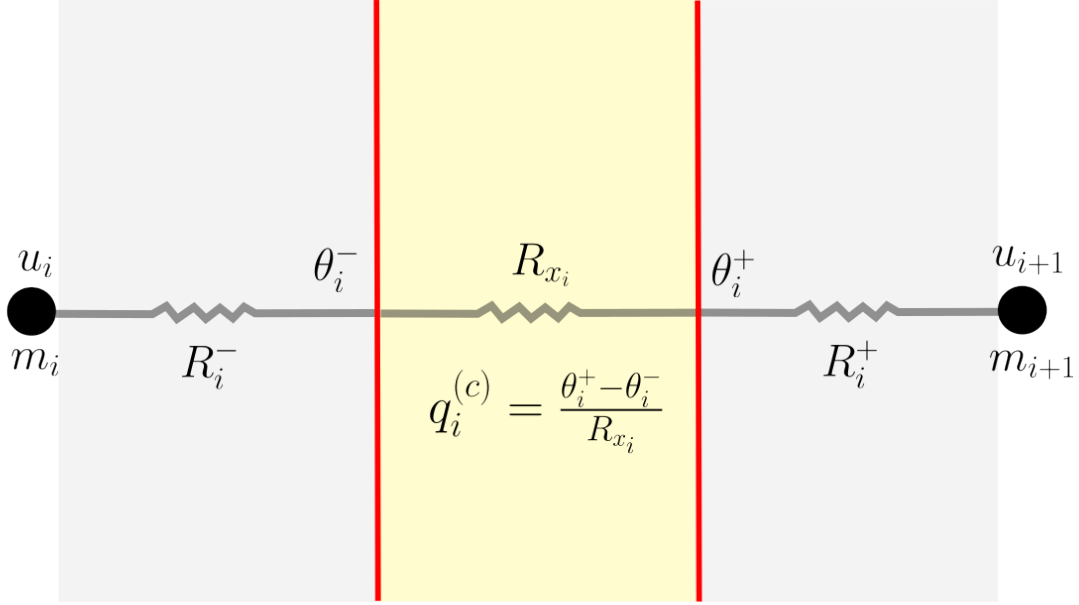
$$\mathbf{K}_1 = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & -1 & 0 & 0 \\ -1 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{K}_2 = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{K}_3 = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 & 1 \end{bmatrix} \quad (9)$$

The effective heat flux through interface i is therefore,

$$q_i = \frac{u_{i+1} - u_i}{S_i(\mathbf{u}) + R_{xi}} \quad (10)$$

where the temperature-drop convention is always taken as,

$$\Delta u_i = u_{i+1} - u_i \quad (11)$$



4 Total drop = bulk drop + contact drop

To separate bulk and contact contributions, introduce interface temperatures

$$\theta_i^+, \quad \theta_i^-, \quad i = 1, 2, 3, \quad (12)$$

where θ_i^- and θ_i^+ are the temperatures immediately to the left and right of contact i , respectively. Define the contact temperature jumps as,

$$\Delta\theta_i := \theta_i^+ - \theta_i^-, \quad i = 1, 2, 3 \quad (13)$$

The total lumped-to-lumped temperature drop across interface i ,

$$u_{i+1} - u_i \quad (14)$$

This total lumped-to-lumped temperature drop is the sum of the bulk drop across the interface and the contact jump across the interface,

$$\underbrace{u_{i+1} - u_i}_{\text{total drop}} = \underbrace{(\theta_i^- - u_i) + (u_{i+1} - \theta_i^+)}_{\text{bulk drop}} + \underbrace{(\theta_i^+ - \theta_i^-)}_{\text{contact drop}}. \quad (15)$$

Hence,

$$\underbrace{(\theta_i^- - u_i) + (u_{i+1} - \theta_i^+)}_{\text{bulk drop}} = \underbrace{(u_{i+1} - u_i)}_{\text{total drop}} - \underbrace{\Delta\theta_i}_{\text{contact drop}} \quad (16)$$

$$\text{bulk drop across interface } i = (u_{i+1} - u_i) - \Delta\theta_i. \quad (17)$$

Thus the lifted state is

$$x = \begin{bmatrix} u \\ \Delta\theta \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} u_1 \\ u_2 \\ u_3 \\ u_4 \\ \Delta\theta_1 \\ \Delta\theta_2 \\ \Delta\theta_3 \end{bmatrix} \in \mathbb{R}^7, \quad \Delta\theta = \begin{bmatrix} \Delta\theta_1 \\ \Delta\theta_2 \\ \Delta\theta_3 \end{bmatrix}.$$

5 Heat-flux Continuity and DAE Formulation

Using the adopted convention, define the bulk and contact heat fluxes as

$$q_i^{(b)} = \frac{(u_{i+1} - u_i) - \Delta\theta_i}{S_i(u)}, \quad q_i^{(c)} = \frac{\Delta\theta_i}{R_{xi}} = g_{xi}\Delta\theta_i. \quad (18)$$

Heat-flux continuity across each interface requires

$$q_i^{(b)} = q_i^{(c)}, \quad i = 1, 2, 3, \quad (19)$$

which yields the algebraic constraints

$$\frac{(u_{i+1} - u_i) - \Delta\theta_i}{S_i(u)} - g_{xi}\Delta\theta_i = 0, \quad i = 1, 2, 3. \quad (20)$$

Lumped-temperature dynamics

The four lumped energy balances yield,

$$a_1(u_1)\dot{u}_1 = f(t) - q_{12}^{(b)} \quad (21a)$$

$$a_2(u_2)\dot{u}_2 = q_{12}^{(b)} - q_{23}^{(b)} \quad (21b)$$

$$a_3(u_3)\dot{u}_3 = q_{23}^{(b)} - q_{34}^{(b)} \quad (21c)$$

$$a_4(u_4)\dot{u}_4 = q_{34}^{(b)} \quad (21d)$$

Substituting using the bulk heat fluxes yields,

$$a_1(u_1)\dot{u}_1 = f(t) - \frac{(u_2 - u_1) - \Delta\theta_1}{S_1(u)} \quad (22a)$$

$$a_2(u_2)\dot{u}_2 = \frac{(u_2 - u_1) - \Delta\theta_1}{S_1(u)} - \frac{(u_3 - u_2) - \Delta\theta_2}{S_2(u)} \quad (22b)$$

$$a_3(u_3)\dot{u}_3 = \frac{(u_3 - u_2) - \Delta\theta_2}{S_2(u)} - \frac{(u_4 - u_3) - \Delta\theta_3}{S_3(u)} \quad (22c)$$

$$a_4(u_4)\dot{u}_4 = \frac{(u_4 - u_3) - \Delta\theta_3}{S_3(u)} \quad (22d)$$

Matrix form of DAE

Define the difference matrix,

$$\mathbf{D} = \begin{bmatrix} -1 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 & 1 \end{bmatrix}, \mathbf{D}u = \begin{bmatrix} u_2 - u_1 \\ u_3 - u_2 \\ u_4 - u_3 \end{bmatrix} \quad (23)$$

Define the bulk temperature stencils,

$$\mathbf{K}_1 = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & -1 & 0 & 0 \\ -1 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}, \mathbf{K}_2 = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}, \mathbf{K}_3 = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 & 1 \end{bmatrix} \quad (24)$$

and the bulk jump-coupling stencils,

$$\mathbf{L}_1 = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ -1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}, \mathbf{L}_2 = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}, \mathbf{L}_3 = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 \end{bmatrix} \quad (25)$$

Then,

$$A(u)\dot{u} = \sum_{i=1}^{N-1} \frac{1}{S_i(u)} (\mathbf{K}_i u + \mathbf{L}_i \Delta \boldsymbol{\theta}) + \mathbf{f}(t) \quad (26)$$

and the algebraic constraints for heat flux continuity are written as,

$$\text{diag}\left(\frac{1}{S_1(u)}, \frac{1}{S_2(u)}, \frac{1}{S_3(u)}\right) \mathbf{D}u - \left[\text{diag}\left(\frac{1}{S_1(u)}, \frac{1}{S_2(u)}, \frac{1}{S_3(u)}\right) + G_x\right] \Delta \boldsymbol{\theta} = 0 \quad (27)$$

where

$$G_x = \begin{bmatrix} g_{x1} & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & g_{x2} & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & g_{x3} \end{bmatrix} \quad (28)$$

Equation (27), along with the lumped-temperature dynamics, defines a DAE system for the lifted state $x = [u, \Delta \boldsymbol{\theta}]$.

6 DAE index reduction

The DAE is index-reduced by differentiating the heat-flux continuity constraints with respect to time, which, for each interface i , yields,

$$\frac{d}{dt} \left[\frac{(u_{i+1} - u_i) - \Delta \theta_i}{S_i(u)} - g_{xi} \Delta \theta_i \right] = 0 \quad (29)$$

The contact conductances g_{xi} are assumed constant, therefore,

$$(1 + g_{xi} S_i(u)) \Delta \dot{\theta}_i = (\dot{u}_{i+1} - \dot{u}_i) - \frac{(u_{i+1} - u_i) - \Delta \theta_i}{S_i(u)} \dot{S}_i(u) \quad (30)$$

Using the original algebraic constraint

$$\frac{(u_{i+1} - u_i) - \Delta\theta_i}{S_i(u)} = g_{xi}\Delta\theta_i, \quad (31)$$

the index-reduced dynamics become,

$$\boxed{\Delta\dot{\theta}_i = \frac{\dot{u}_{i+1} - \dot{u}_i - g_{xi}\Delta\theta_i \dot{S}_i(u)}{1 + g_{xi}S_i(u)}, \quad i = 1, 2, 3} \quad (32)$$

Define

$$M(u; R_x) = \begin{bmatrix} 1 + g_{x1}S_1(u) & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 + g_{x2}S_2(u) & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 + g_{x3}S_3(u) \end{bmatrix} \quad (33)$$

and,

$$\dot{S}(u) = \begin{bmatrix} \dot{S}_1(u) \\ \dot{S}_2(u) \\ \dot{S}_3(u) \end{bmatrix}, \quad \Delta\theta \odot \dot{S}(u) = \begin{bmatrix} \Delta\theta_1 \dot{S}_1(u) \\ \Delta\theta_2 \dot{S}_2(u) \\ \Delta\theta_3 \dot{S}_3(u) \end{bmatrix} \quad (34)$$

Then, the index-reduced dynamics for the contact jumps can be written in matrix form as,

$$M(u; R_x)\Delta\dot{\theta} = D\dot{u} - G_x(\Delta\theta \odot \dot{S}(u)) \quad (35)$$

Thus, the index-reduced lifted system is given by the coupled ODEs,

$$A(u)\dot{u} = \sum_{i=1}^{N-1} \frac{1}{S_i(u)} (\mathbf{K}_i u + \mathbf{L}_i \Delta\theta) + \mathbf{f}(t) \quad (36a)$$

$$M(u; R_x)\Delta\dot{\theta} = \mathbf{D}\dot{u} - G_x(\Delta\theta \odot \dot{S}(u)) \quad (36b)$$

7 Physics-Infused Reduced-Order Modeling

The formulation of PIROM for TPS starts by mathematically connecting the FOM, i.e., the DG-FEM, to the RPM, i.e., the LCM. This results presented in this section leverage the previous work in Ref. X, where a coarse-graining procedure is developed to systematically derive the LCM from the DG-FEM. Such coarse-graining procedure pinpoints the missing dynamics in the LCM when compared to DG-FEM, enabling the systematic design of a memory closure to account for residual dynamics associated with discarded spatial resolution.

8 Bulk-only Mori–Zwanzig Memory Closure

The purpose of the closure is to account for the unresolved dynamics in the LCM, while leaving the contact-jump dynamics unchanged. Accordingly, the

Accordingly, write the Projected Generalized Langevin Equation (PGLE) for the lumped-temperature dynamics,

$$A(\mathbf{u})\dot{\mathbf{u}} = \sum_{i=1}^{N-1} \frac{1}{S_i(\mathbf{u})} (\mathbf{K}_i u + \mathbf{L}_i \Delta\theta) + \mathbf{f}(t) + \int_{t_0}^t \kappa(t, s, u, \mathbf{f}; \Theta) ds \quad (37)$$

Now, ensure the designed memory modifies only the bulk conductances, i.e.,

$$\boldsymbol{\kappa} \in \text{span} \{ \mathbf{K}_1 u(t), \mathbf{K}_2 u(t), \mathbf{K}_3 u(t), \mathbf{L}_1 \Delta \boldsymbol{\theta}_1(t), \mathbf{L}_2 \Delta \boldsymbol{\theta}_2(t), \mathbf{L}_3 \Delta \boldsymbol{\theta}_3(t) \} \quad (38)$$

which leads to,

$$\boldsymbol{\kappa}(t, s, u, \mathbf{f}; \Theta) \approx \sum_{j=1}^m \kappa_j(t, s, u, \mathbf{f}; \Theta) \mathcal{P}_j \quad (39)$$

where,

$$\mathcal{P}_j = \sum_{i=1}^{N-1} \frac{1}{S_i(u)} \mathbf{P}_{ij} \quad (40)$$

Now, define the memory variables as,

$$\beta_j(t) = \int_{t_0}^t \kappa_j(t, s, u, \mathbf{f}; \Theta) ds \quad (41)$$

then,

$$\int_{t_0}^t \boldsymbol{\kappa}(t, s, u, \mathbf{f}; \Theta) ds = \sum_{j=1}^m \beta_j(t) \mathcal{P}_j \quad (42)$$

It follows that,

$$\sum_{j=1}^m \beta_j(t) \mathcal{P}_j = \sum_{j=1}^m \beta_j(t) \sum_{i=1}^{N-1} \frac{1}{S_i(u)} \mathbf{P}_{ij} = \sum_{i=1}^{N-1} \frac{1}{S_i(u)} \left(\sum_{j=1}^m \mathbf{P}_{ij} \beta_j(t) \right) = \sum_{i=1}^{N-1} \frac{1}{S_i(u)} \mathbf{P}_i \boldsymbol{\beta} \quad (43)$$

Then, the memory correction to the LCM dynamics leads to the following modified lumped-temperature dynamics,

$$A(\mathbf{u}) \dot{\mathbf{u}} = \sum_{i=1}^{N-1} \frac{1}{S_i(\mathbf{u})} (\mathbf{K}_i u + \mathbf{L}_i \Delta \boldsymbol{\theta} + \mathbf{P}_i \boldsymbol{\beta}) + \mathbf{f}(t) \quad (44)$$

Now, let,

$$\kappa_i(t, s, \mathbf{u}, \mathbf{f}; \Theta) = e^{-\lambda_j(t-s)} \left(q_j^\top \phi(\mathbf{u}(s)) + r_j^\top \psi(\mathbf{f}(s)) \right) \quad (45)$$

such that the memory variables are given by,

$$\boldsymbol{\beta}(t) = \int_{t_0}^t e^{-\Lambda(t-s)} \left(Q^\top \phi(\mathbf{u}(s)) + R^\top \psi(\mathbf{f}(s)) \right) ds \quad (46)$$

The hidden dynamics are now given by,

$$\dot{\boldsymbol{\beta}} = -\Lambda \boldsymbol{\beta} + Q^\top \phi(\mathbf{u}) + R^\top \psi(\mathbf{f}) \quad (47)$$

and in state-space form, the hidden dynamics are,

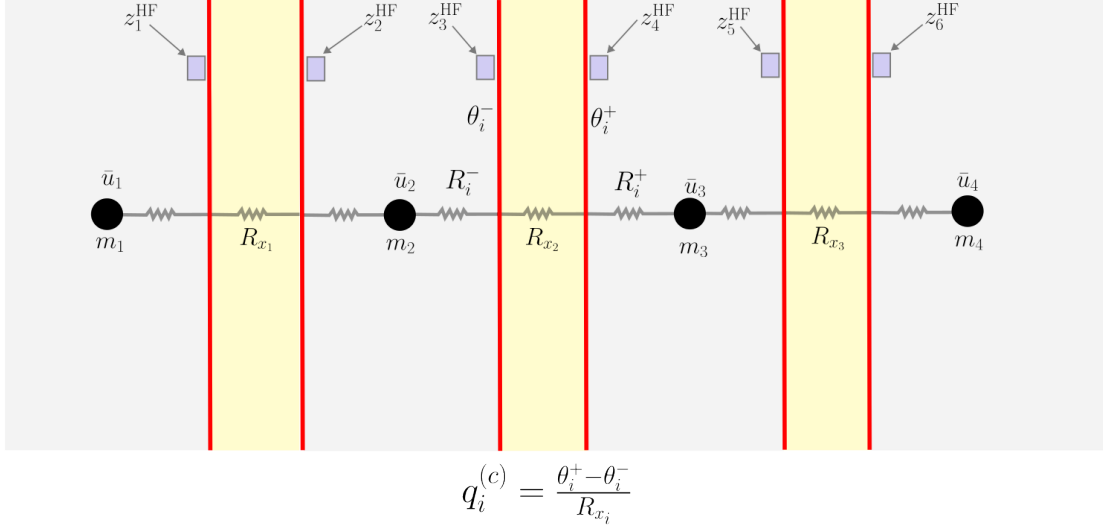
$$\dot{\boldsymbol{\beta}} = -\Lambda \boldsymbol{\beta} + Q^\top \phi(\mathbf{u}) + R^\top \psi(\mathbf{f}) \quad (48)$$

The full lifted and closed system is given by,

$$A(\mathbf{u}) \dot{\mathbf{u}} = \sum_{i=1}^{N-1} \frac{1}{S_i(\mathbf{u})} (\mathbf{K}_i \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{L}_i \Delta \boldsymbol{\theta} + \mathbf{P}_i \boldsymbol{\beta}) + \mathbf{f}(t) \quad (49a)$$

$$M(\mathbf{u}; R_x) \dot{\Delta \boldsymbol{\theta}} = \mathbf{D} \dot{\mathbf{u}} - G_x(\Delta \boldsymbol{\theta} \odot \dot{S}(\mathbf{u})) \quad (49b)$$

$$\dot{\boldsymbol{\beta}} = -\Lambda \boldsymbol{\beta} + Q^\top \phi(\mathbf{u}) + R^\top \psi(\mathbf{f}) \quad (49c)$$



9 Application to Thermal Protection Systems

In this section, the proposed PIROM approach is applied to modeling a four-layered hypersonic TPS with unknown contact resistances, and is compared against a representative physics-based model, i.e., FEMs, and data-driven surrogate model, i.e., a neural ordinary differential equation (NODE) model. The performance of the models is assessed in terms of their ability to infer the TCRs, and to predict the transient temperature dynamics under varying boundary conditions and material properties. The configuration of the TPS, problem parametrization, optimal model design for inference, and numerical results are presented next.

9.1 Configuration of Thermal Protection System

9.2 Problem Parametrization

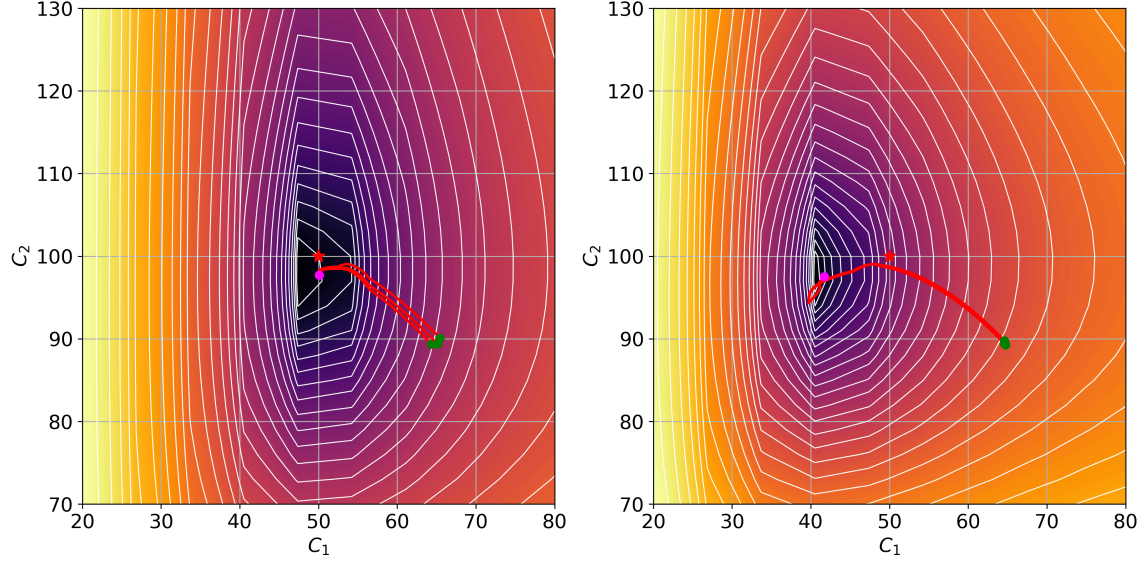
9.3 Optimal Model Design for Inference

This section presents the procedure for optimally selecting the physics-based model for inferring the TCR. Two critical design choices are discussed: (i) formulation of the physics-based model, and (ii) experimental limitations. In the first design choice, the resolution of the physics-based model is selected to balance the trade-off between model bias and computational cost. In the second design choice, experimental limitations, such as the number of thermocouples and their placement, are selected to ensure the identifiability of the TCR inference problem.

9.3.1 Resolution of the Physics-Based Model

The dimensionality of the physics-based model is critical for the performance of the PIROM, as it directly affects the computational cost and identifiability of the TCR inference problem. A coarse model may introduce undesirable model biases that can compromise the accuracy of the inferred TCRs, while a highly-refined model may introduce unnecessary computational costs that hinder efficiency during inference.

One-Dimensional Finite-Element Model



Lumped Capacitance Model

Lumped Capacitance Model with Jump Dynamics

9.3.2 Thermocouple Placement

In addition to the resolution of the physics-based model, the placement of the thermocouples is also critical for the performance of the PIROM, as it directly affects the identifiability of the TCR inference problem.

10 Numerical Results

The main conclusion of this work are as follows,

1. The PIROM framework successfully learns a ROM for the prediction of the temperature dynamics of the TPS, while simultaneously inferring the unknown contact conductances with errors of less than X% on noisy data with SNR of up to Y dB.
2. The PIROM outperforms the state-of-the-art data-driven, NN-based SciML, and traditional FEM modeling approaches for inferring contact conductances, as well as for predicting the temperature dynamics for OOD configurations.
3. The PIROM is successfully deployed in an experimental setting, where it is able to infer the contact conductances and predict the temperature dynamics with errors of less than X% on noisy data with SNR of up to Y dB.